Advanced Expressions in New Scientist

17 October 2026 issue · advanced (C1–C2) vocabulary and expressions with their exact sentences, in page order. Idioms are in the separate idioms PDF; all 52 pages were checked.

The leader & El Niño special report (pages 3–10)

#	Expression / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
1	**dull the worst impacts of** reduce the most severe effects of	More speculatively, there are proposals to **dull the worst impacts of** El Niño through geoengineering efforts.	3
2	**it is within our power to** we are able to; it is in our control	Though El Niño is a natural cycle within Earth's delicate climate system, **it's within our power to** avoid its worst effects.	3
3	**superlatives have been flying about** people keep using extreme words of praise/description	**Superlatives have been flying about** the current El Niño climate pattern, which is already the strongest on record months before it is expected to peak.	4
4	**with repercussions across the globe** with serious consequences everywhere	…transferring huge quantities of heat to the atmosphere, **with repercussions across the globe**.	5
5	**remain unresolved** still not settled or answered	The question of whether global warming is making El Niños stronger **is unresolved**, says Michael Mann at the University of Pennsylvania.	5
6	**no firm conclusion can be drawn** nothing can be decided with certainty	…there are crucial gaps in the coral record that mean **no firm conclusion can be drawn**.	5
7	**amplify the damage** make the harm greater	What is clear is that warming **amplifies the damage** done by El Niños.	5
8	**push across a threshold** force past a critical limit	…various components of the Earth system are **pushed toward, or even across, regime-shift thresholds**.	6
9	**worse than your imagination could conjure** more terrible than you can imagine	TO READ of the great famine that swept the globe in the 1870s is to read of a hellscape **worse than your imagination could conjure**.	6
10	**in desperate bids to** in frantic attempts to	They ate diseased animals, tree roots, mud, pets and strips of leather **in desperate bids to** stay alive.	6
11	**by many contemporary accounts** according to many reports written at that time	**By many contemporary accounts**, cannibalism was **rife**.	6
12	**rife** very common (of something bad)	By many contemporary accounts, cannibalism was **rife**.	6
13	**succumb** die or be defeated by something	Once the poor had died in a region, the wealthy **succumbed**.	6

The leader & El Niño special report (pages 3–10)			
#	**Expression / meaning**	**Sentence in the magazine**	**Page**
14	**of truly planetary magnitude** of enormous, worldwide scale	As historian Mike Davis writes in the book Late Victorian Holocausts, this was a disaster **of “truly planetary magnitude”**.	**6**
15	**in the immediate aftermath of** in the period just after (a disaster)	**In the immediate aftermath of** the El Niño, many researchers were convinced sunspots were to blame.	**6**
16	**usher in (an idea / era)** introduce; mark the start of	That was the “big bang” for El Niño research … **ushering in the idea** that with the right data and equipment, El Niños could be identified in real time.	**6**
17	**afford (someone) time** give or provide (formal)	That **affords** governments, emergency services, farmers and citizens vital time to prepare.	**7**
18	**severely curtailed** greatly reduced or restricted	…US federal funding for climate research and global aid has been **severely curtailed**.	**7**
19	**patchy** uneven; incomplete in places	Six months later it was reinstated, but data reporting since then has been **patchy**, news reports suggest.	**7**
20	**scale back** reduce in size or amount	Other high-income countries, including the UK, have also **scaled back** their overseas aid budgets in recent years.	**7**
21	**the ineptitude of** the lack of skill or competence of	Back in 1877-78, **the ineptitude of** governments’ official responses worsened the impacts.	**7**
22	**unleash (drought) on** suddenly release a destructive force on	Almost all recent El Niños have **unleashed drought on** Brazil, Vietnam, Colombia and Indonesia, the world’s top four coffee producers.	**8**
23	**multiple breadbasket failure** crop failure in several major food-growing regions at once	In the case of “**multiple breadbasket failure**”, replacement supplies become difficult to find, and a staple can become **brutally expensive** or unavailable.	**8**
24	**brutally expensive** extremely, painfully expensive	…a staple can become **brutally expensive** or unavailable.	**8**
25	**a compounding shock** a new crisis that makes existing ones worse	…El Niño drought will be a “**compounding shock**” on top of existing problems like conflict.	**9**
26	**social unrest** public protest and disorder	…this combination could lead to “**social unrest** and conflict in vulnerable countries, much as the global wheat crisis became a trigger of the Arab Spring”.	**9**
27	**scrutinise readiness for** examine carefully how prepared we are for	A task force … will meet this month to **scrutinise readiness for** climate security threats, including to food.	**9**
28	**ranging from the outrageously radical to …** covering everything from extreme to practical	…engineers working on ideas **ranging from the outrageously radical to the just-might-work**.	**10**
29	**technical feasibility** whether something can practically be done	But – and it is a big but – the **technical feasibility** of deploying artificial upwelling on this scale would be a “major, major undertaking”, she says.	**10**

The leader & El Niño special report (pages 3–10)

#	Expression / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
30	**a major undertaking** a very large, difficult task	…would be a “**major, major undertaking**”, she says.	10

AI & science news (pages 12–16)

#	Expression / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
31	**an astonishing range of** an amazingly wide variety of	…OpenAI released 722 mathematical papers using an AI model to examine **an astonishing range of** topics.	12
32	**having achieved depth, opt for breadth** after going deep, choose to cover more widely	**Having achieved impressive depth**, OpenAI has seemingly now **opted for breadth**.	12
33	**dense with** packed full of (difficult content)	…some of the papers are hundreds of pages long, **dense with** complex computations.	12
34	**a thicket of** a large, confusing mass of	Nevertheless, even a preliminary comb through **the thicket of** papers turns up some that are likely to make a splash.	12
35	**hold up to scrutiny** remain valid after close examination	…it could take years for mathematicians to check, and far longer to understand its significance, if it **holds up to scrutiny**.	13
36	**minuscule improvements** extremely tiny improvements	Other papers provide **minuscule improvements** in algorithmic power.	13
37	**a forebear of** an ancestor of	A SEMI-AQUATIC **forebear of** all living mammals that lived between 163 million and 168 million years ago was the first known animal capable of feeding by suckling.	13
38	**sit at a key point in** occupy an important position in	Oliver Griffith … says this fossil **sits at a key point in** mammalian evolution.	13
39	**an unprecedented glimpse into** a never-before-possible view of	The finds have given **an unprecedented glimpse into** everyday Neanderthal life.	15
40	**a very biased picture of** a one-sided, distorted view of	“The archaeological record gives us **a very biased picture of** prehistoric technology.”	15
41	**a wider repertoire of** a broader range of skills	Chris Stringer … says the finds reveal a much **wider technological repertoire of** woodworking skills.	15
42	**add to the body of evidence** provide more support for a theory	“This study **adds to the body of evidence** that the mechanisms of ageing may be **conserved across species**.”	16
43	**conserved across species** (biology) kept unchanged through evolution in many species	“…the mechanisms of ageing may be **conserved across species**,” says Stephen Clark.	16

Views – Hannah Fry & Alice Klein (pages 19–20)

#	Expression / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
44	**staggeringly beautiful** astonishingly beautiful	They are **staggeringly beautiful**, able to articulate everything from the drip of a water droplet on a leaf to the gases swirling around in a galaxy in the sky.	19
45	**an intimidating mystique** a mysterious, frightening reputation	Maths had **an intimidating mystique** to maintain, and I was apparently jeopardising it.	19
46	**puncture (a mystique)** destroy an illusion or reputation	He was right that there is a mystique to maths, but wrong about who would **puncture it**.	19
47	**there is some inevitability to** it is bound to happen that	I know that **there is some inevitability to** machines outpacing humans.	19
48	**an engine of extraction** a system that takes value from others	But at its worst, AI is **an engine of extraction**.	19
49	**choose conquest over stewardship** prefer domination to responsible care	But the moment when one of humanity's greatest intellectual traditions became vulnerable, it **chose conquest over stewardship**.	19
50	**a neat natural experiment** a clever real-life situation that works like a controlled study	My interest was thus piqued by a recent study that used **a neat natural experiment** to investigate the long-term health effects of sugar exposure.	20
51	**be enthusiastically embraced** be eagerly accepted again	When sugar rationing ended in the UK in 1953, sugar was **enthusiastically embraced** again.	20

Culture & letters (pages 26–31)

#	Expression / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
52	**cognitive atrophy** weakening of mental abilities through lack of use	…what I lose personally if relying on AI leads to some sort of **cognitive atrophy**.	26
53	**surrender intellectual effort** give up thinking for ourselves	…and what becomes of us all when we **surrender intellectual effort**.	26
54	**a clear-minded manifesto for** a clear, rational statement of beliefs supporting	The book amounts to **a clear-minded manifesto for** cautiously embracing AI.	26
55	**relinquish** give up (formal)	…how each of us can collaborate with it effectively without **relinquishing** our most valuable cognitive capabilities.	26
56	**leaven (it) with** make lighter or more interesting by adding	…**leavening it all with** examples of his gratifyingly meta conversations with the likes of Claude, Gemini and ChatGPT.	26
57	**be candid about** be honest and open about	It is all thorough and measured, and he is **candid about** the many uncertainties, despite **tending towards the optimistic**.	27

Culture & letters (pages 26–31)

#	Expression / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
58	**tend towards the optimistic** lean towards a hopeful view	…despite **tending towards the optimistic**.	27
59	**cleverly foreshadowed by** hinted at earlier in a skilful way	There is an intriguing passage, for instance – **cleverly foreshadowed by** a disconcerting exchange with Claude.	27
60	**ponder fate and predetermination** think deeply about destiny	I found it deeper, as it **ponders fate and predetermination**.	27
61	**chastened by** made humble/sorry by	Now, **chastened by** the praise the book has received from others, as well as the awards it has **garnered**, I have returned to it.	28
62	**garner (awards)** gather or win (praise, awards)	…as well as the awards it has **garnered**.	28
63	**an audacious piece of work** a boldly daring piece of work	Swift's book is actually an extremely ambitious, even **audacious piece of work**.	28
64	**braid together (stories)** weave separate stories into one	The novel, which ends in about 2070, **braids together** the stories of Lucy and Hester over the decades.	28
65	**get into an infinite regress** create an endless chain of reasoning	We have immediately **got ourselves into an infinite regress**.	31
66	**a wider appreciation of** a broader understanding of	…this might change if there were **a wider appreciation of** the real costs of adaptation.	31

AI's inner life – consciousness feature (pages 32–35)

#	Expression / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
67	**the defining topic of our era** the most important issue of our time	"It's **the defining topic of our era** that we will have to **grapple with** practically and socially," says philosopher Ned Block.	32
68	**grapple with** struggle to deal with or understand	"…that we will have to **grapple with** practically and socially."	32
69	**something akin to** something similar to	…Anthropic published a paper arguing that Claude had recently developed **something akin to** the human mind's "global workspace".	32
70	**emergent properties** features that arise unexpectedly from a complex system	…these **emergent properties** may allow us to understand what the differences between us are.	32
71	**be best placed to** be the most suitable to	Many neuroscientists and philosophers believe that the global neuronal workspace theory (GNWT) **is best placed to** address access consciousness.	32

AI’s inner life – consciousness feature (pages 32–35)

#	Expression / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
72	**amass considerable evidence** collect a large amount of proof	Over the past 30 years, Dehaene and his colleagues have **amassed considerable evidence** for the existence of the global workspace.	33
73	**a rudimentary sign of** a basic, early-stage indication of	Hiding “thoughts” is **a rudimentary sign of** self-monitoring in LLMs, says Dehaene.	34
74	**it is far from obvious that** it is not at all clear that	…but **it is far from obvious that** the same would be true of a silicon system.	35
75	**be incomparable to** be impossible to compare with	…much like an environmental simulation **is incomparable to** the weather itself.	35
76	**there is little consensus on** people largely disagree about	**There is still little consensus on** which elements matter, and which don’t, for phenomenal experience.	35
77	**have little patience for** be unwilling to tolerate	Dehaene **has little patience for** the idea that AIs can only be conscious if they mimic our biology.	35
78	**bolster the case for** strengthen the argument for	Finding an analogue in LLMs might help **bolster the case for** machine consciousness.	35
79	**offer definitive evidence** give final, conclusive proof	Such tests cannot **offer definitive evidence**, however, which may make it difficult to ever reach a consensus.	35
80	**formulate lines of inquiry** develop directions of research	…he believes these discussions will ultimately help us **formulate more sophisticated lines of inquiry**.	35

Cancer & space features (pages 37–43)

#	Expression / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
81	**quietly revolutionising** transforming completely without publicity	…a new kind of test that is **quietly revolutionising** treatment.	37
82	**inflict mass damage** cause widespread harm	This is like dropping a large bomb on the body, **inflicting mass damage** and causing side effects like fatigue, nausea and hair loss.	37
83	**rationally design** create logically, based on scientific understanding	“…and **rationally designing** drugs to target those individual genes, we are making rapid strides.”	37
84	**make rapid strides** make fast progress	“…we are **making rapid strides**.”	37
85	**exhaust all available options** use up every possible choice	It enrolled almost 4000 people with advanced cancers … who had **exhausted all available treatment options**.	38
86	**outlooks have become increasingly rosy** prospects are looking better and better	The **outlooks** for these participants **have become increasingly rosy**.	38

Cancer & space features (pages 37–43)

#	Expression / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
87	**a patchwork of** an uncoordinated mix of	The US doesn’t have a nationally coordinated precision oncology programme, instead relying on **a patchwork of** services.	38
88	**devise workarounds** invent ways to get around a problem	…over time, a person’s cancer can **devise workarounds**.	39
89	**be precisely tailored** be adjusted exactly to suit	…his ongoing monitoring can **be precisely tailored**.	39
90	**the run-up to** the period leading to an event	…but **the run-up to** this had been going so incredibly well.	41
91	**exquisite (measurements)** extremely precise and fine	The weak lensing measurements for Roman are going to be **exquisite**, because some of the most stringent requirements on the design of the telescope are related to making this weak lensing measurement.	42
92	**constrain or narrow down** limit the range of possibilities	…it can help **constrain or narrow down** some of the dark matter candidates.	43

Back pages (pages 46–48)

#	Expression / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
93	**a conspicuous signal of** a very noticeable sign of	They provide **a conspicuous signal of** distress or vulnerability and may encourage sympathy or reduce aggression.	46
94	**be open to exploitation** be easy to misuse for someone’s advantage	But any useful signal **is open to exploitation**.	46
95	**complicate matters further** make a situation even more complex	Actors **complicate matters further** because some can deliberately **summon a genuine emotional response** and cry on demand.	46
96	**summon (a response)** call up or produce deliberately	…some can deliberately **summon a genuine emotional response** and cry on demand.	46
97	**venerable** respected because of age and long history	…this year is the 60th anniversary of the **venerable** sci-fi franchise Star Trek.	48
98	**find (something) immediately baffling** be confused by it at once	“Participants rated their attractiveness on a 0–100 scale,” which Feedback **finds immediately baffling**.	48
99	**decidedly non-evidence-based** clearly not supported by evidence	…the DISC test invented by the creator of Wonder Woman, which is **decidedly non-evidence-based**.	48
100	**a vast literature on** a huge number of published studies on	“There is **a vast literature on** the beauty premium.”	48
101	**a considerable asset** a significant advantage	…physical attractiveness is **a considerable asset** in all competitive situations such as mate selection.	48

Back pages (pages 46–48)

#	Expression / meaning	Sentence in the magazine	Page
102	**inherently competitive** competitive by its very nature	Feedback cannot quite get over how many people think of dating as **inherently competitive**.	**48**